Eunsun Kim

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Education

University of California, Los Angeles, Ph.D. in Quantitative Marketing — Expected 2027

Duke University, M.S. in Economics and Computation — 2021

Seoul National University, M.S. in Quantitative Marketing — 2019

Seoul National University, B.A. in Business — 2017
summa cum laude; Minor in Economics

Research Interests

Quantitative Marketing, Empirical Industrial Organization, Reinforcement Learning, Algorithmic Pricing

Job Market Paper

Following to Lead: Dominant Followership in Sequential Price Competition [Draft]

A dominant platform might be expected to use its market position to charge more than its rivals, even for the same products. Amazon does not. Using synchronized high-frequency cross-platform pricing data, I find that Amazon prices at or below the lowest rival price. Its distinctive role appears instead in the sequence of price adjustments, where I document three patterns. First, Amazon raises price most frequently, yet its increases are least likely to establish new market highs. Second, Amazon follows more than it is followed, and exact matching is common among its observed following responses. Third, when Amazon follows a rival's initiating price increase, the initiating rival tends to maintain its higher price for longer. I call this strategy dominant followership. In addition to documenting this strategy, I provide a stylized model as a potential explanation. A sequential Bertrand model modified to break ties in favor of the dominant firm shows why dominant followership can raise prices above the simultaneous-move Nash benchmark. Because the dominant firm keeps most demand at price parity, it may prefer matching a rival's higher price to undercutting it. The rival is willing to raise price first when that match is predictable. Using simulations, I show that Q-learning algorithms learn dominant-followership behavior endogenously; individually optimal responses can teach rival algorithms that raising prices is profitable, even without explicit coordination. The firm that learns to initiate higher prices need not be the main beneficiary: the rival's algorithm learns to initiate increases, nearly tripling the market price, while the dominant firm captures 91 percent of the resulting gains. The main insight of this paper is that a dominant firm can support higher equilibrium prices by strategically moving second, even while charging no more than its rival. Relative prices alone therefore need not reveal how market power operates in sequential price competition.

Working Papers

Can Consumer AI Discipline Algorithmic Pricing?

This project studies whether consumer-side AI shopping agents can weaken dominant-platform pricing power in markets where firms use pricing algorithms. Many consumers begin product search inside a dominant platform and compare only a limited set of alternatives, allowing firms to benefit from search frictions and default position. AI shopping agents can change this environment by searching across platforms, tracking recent price histories, and making price and non-price tradeoffs easier to compare. However, lower search costs need not eliminate platform advantage, because consumers may still value the dominant platform's non-price advantages, such as delivery speed, return convenience, and trust. I model consumer-side AI as lowering search frictions and expanding consumers' consideration sets, which reduces the dominant firm's demand advantage. Starting from a market in which the dominant platform captures a large share of demand, I ask how pricing incentives change as AI agents make consumers more willing to consider rival sellers. The main exercise is a threshold analysis: how much must the dominant firm's demand advantage fall before the dominant-followership mechanism breaks down? I then examine the implications for consumer welfare. The project speaks to a policy question in algorithmic pricing: whether consumer-side AI can discipline dominant platforms through better search, or whether dominant-platform advantages are too persistent for the market to self-correct.

Honors and Research Grants

AMA-Sheth Consortium Fellow 2026
NBER Digital Economics and AI Tutorial 2025
Haring Symposium Fellow 2025
ISMS Doctoral Consortium Fellow 2023, 2025
Price Center for Entrepreneurship and Innovation Research Grant 2024
Grand Prize, Mock Fair Trade Commission Contest, Korea Fair Trade Commission 2017
Dean's List, Seoul National University Business School 2015, 2016

Presentations

Following to Lead: Dominant Followership in Sequential Price Competition
Industrial Organization Proseminar, Department of Economics, UCLA 2025, 2026
World Congress of the Econometric Society (ESWC) 2025
ISMS Marketing Science Conference 2025
Artificial Intelligence in Management (AIM) Conference 2025

Discussions

Haring Symposium 2025
California Quantitative Marketing Ph.D. Student Conference 2023, 2024

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, UCLA Anderson School of Management 2022–present
Customer Assessment and Analytics (MBA elective), Brett Hollenbeck, Robert Zeithammer
Data and Decisions (MFE course), H. Tai Lam
Statistical Foundations for Data Analytics (MSBA course), Peter Rossi

Teaching Assistant, Department of Computer Science, Duke University 2021
Everything Data

Graduate Assistant, Center for Data and Visualization Sciences, Duke University 2020

Teaching Assistant, Seoul National University Business School 2018–2019
Data-Driven Marketing Analytics
Marketing Management

Past Employment

Mobile Market Research Team, LG Display 2017
Intern, Corporate Law Team, Barun Law LLC 2015

Programming

Python, R, MATLAB, C++, LaTeX

Selected Coursework

University of California, Los Angeles
Theory in Marketing, Robert Zeithammer
Theory of the Firm and Consumer, Ichiro Obara
Game Theory and Information Economics, Moritz Meyer-ter-Vehn
Advanced Econometrics II, Rosa Matzkin
Econometrics III, Rosa Matzkin
Advanced Econometrics III, Denis Chetverikov
Methods Econometrics, Peter Rossi
Econometrics I, Jinyong Hahn
Quantitative Research in Marketing, Brett Hollenbeck and Elisabeth Honka
Industrial Organization, Price Policy, and Regulation, John Asker, Martin Hackmann, and Will Rafey
Applied Analysis of Behavioral Research, Stephen Spiller

Duke University
Computational Microeconomics, Vincent Conitzer
Computer Vision, Carlo Tomasi
Theory and Algorithms for Machine Learning, Cynthia Rudin
Probabilistic Machine Learning, Eric B. Laber
Bayesian and Modern Statistics, Olanrewaju Akande
High-Dimensional Data Analysis, Paul Bendich

Extracurricular

Certified Yoga Instructor, CorePower Yoga

REFERENCES

For letters of recommendation, please contact amy.corrales@anderson.ucla.edu.

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